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Rose

September 1942

Rose crouched on Quai du Châtelet, pencil poised between her fingers, and sketchbook balanced on her lap. Her hand darted across the paper. It had taken nearly a week to draw the Georges V Bridge—the principal crossing connecting the historic heart of Orléans with the Loire River's southern bank.

Today, she focused on the metal deck covering the bridge's missing arch, hatching fine lines and softening them with her finger to add texture and depth. It was when she was drawing that she felt truly alive. She carried a sketchbook everywhere, just in case something caught her eye. Léa, her elder sister, often remarked that Rose not only had talent but also the rare ability to detach herself from what was happening around her. For Rose, it was simple: if she was drawing, she was happy.

For the next hour, she captured the autumn light's long silhouettes and the golden glow on the bridge's metal deck.

A spear-like shadow fell across her sketchbook. Startled, she looked up. A German soldier, his figure looming large, stood over her.

"*Verboten*," he said, pointing at a sign not far off.

It was written in both German and French—*Quai fermé. Accès interdit*. "Embankment closed. Access prohibited". A wave of confusion ran down Rose's back. Every day this week, she'd come to the riverbank to draw the bridge, but this was the first time she'd noticed the sign. Had it been put up this morning?

"*Militarboot*," he shouted, turning to the barge docked at the embankment and the men unloading it.